

discomfort for the players in the CWC. Also, the organisers scheduling afternoon kick-offs to help TV audiences in Europe and Africa watch matches at convenient times have also been met with criticism.

From a footballing perspective, the primary question being raised is how organisers plan to tackle this issue during the FIFA World Cup next year, where the USA is one of the three host countries. Scheduled to take place around the same time (June 11-July 19), similar halts will put a damper on football's biggest festival. The extreme temperatures also prompted FIFA to slash ticket prices for a number of matches, and if the same trend continues for the World Cup next year, it may lead to more logistical nightmares for organisers, who may have to brace for major economic ramifications.

Chelsea's Enzo Fernandez spoke about the sweltering temperatures, saying it is "impossible" to have a normal training session because of the heat.

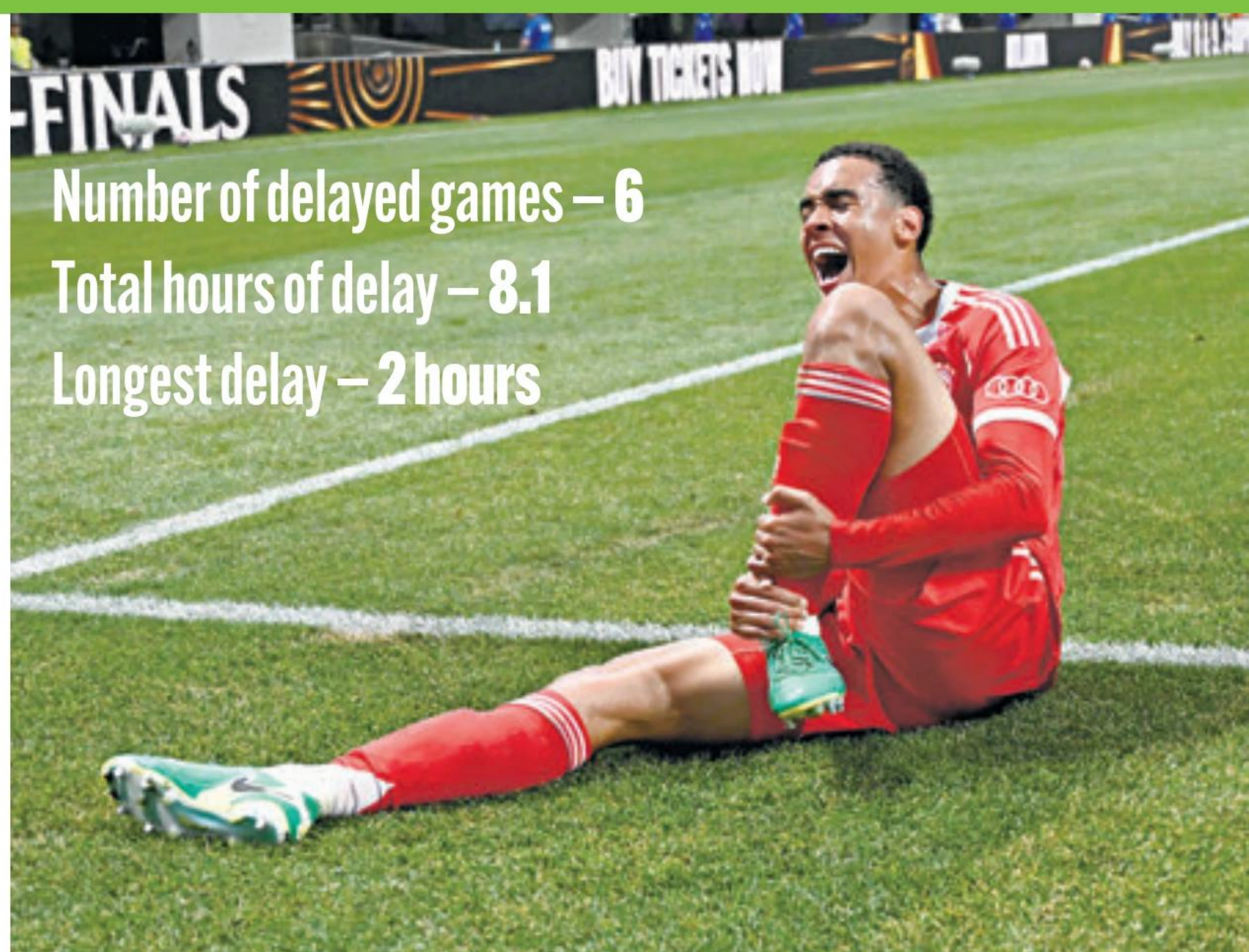
"Honestly, the heat is incredible. The other day, I had to lie down on the ground because I was really dizzy. Playing in this temperature is very dangerous, it's very dangerous. The speed of the game is not the same, everything becomes very slow."

Fernandez, a likely member of Argentina's World Cup 2026 squad, added, "Well, let's hope that next year they change the schedule, at least so that it remains a beautiful and attractive football spectacle, right?"

Pitch imperfect

The USA is steadily making progress in integrating football [or soccer, as it is known there] into one of its mainstream sports. However, it is not quite there yet, and a big indication of that is the poor pitch conditions, which have drawn complaints from players and managers — something almost unheard of in countries with rich footballing cultures like Spain or England.

A major reason for this is that several grounds use artificial turf instead of natural grass, which increases injury risk for players and



Big setback: Bayern Munich's Jamal Musiala will take at least four to five months to recover from the horror injury he sustained against PSG. REUTERS

disrupts the natural movement of the football.

PSG manager Luis Enrique (**below**) did not mince words when criticising the pitch after his side's 2-0 win against Seattle Sounders, saying FIFA needs to "bear in mind" the quality of both match and training pitches. "I wouldn't imagine an NBA court full of holes. What I really care about is the state of the field of play. The ball bounces almost like it was jumping around like a rabbit," said the Spaniard. Bellingham also called out the poor quality of pitches after Real



Madrid's 3-1 win against Pachuca.

"The pitches aren't great at all. It holds up the ball, and the ball barely bounces. It's tough on the knees as well. Hopefully, there's someone who will look at that going into the World Cup next year."

The initial reception from FIFA has been slightly positive, perhaps because it has publicly acknowledged that there is a problem. Former Arsenal manager Arsene Wenger, who is FIFA's Global Football Development chief, admitted: "I've been personally on the pitch at Orlando. It's not at the level that European clubs are used to because it's not perfect, but that will be rectified for the World Cup next year."

The USA has already hosted a World Cup in 1994, but a lot has changed since then. Modern football demands precision, the highest standards and top-notch facilities. The FIFA World Cup is football's biggest tournament, and organisers should give it the respect it deserves. It looks like the CWC has given a crucial reality check.

The USA has fewer than 365 days to get ready. Time is short, and the clock is ticking fast.